



UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY (UNGA)

Background Paper

Topic:

Alleged Illegal U.S. Incursions into Venezuelan Territory and the Principle of Sovereignty

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I. The United Nations General Assembly: History and Powers

The United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations, established in 1945 after the devastation of World War II.

Historical Background

The United Nations was founded on October 24, 1945, with the signing of the UN Charter. It replaced the League of Nations, which had failed to prevent global conflict.

The General Assembly was created as the main deliberative, policymaking, and representative body of the UN. All 193 Member States are equally represented, each holding one vote regardless of their political or economic power.

Its creation reflected a global commitment to:

- Prevent future wars
- Protect state sovereignty
- Promote international cooperation
- Uphold human rights
- Strengthen multilateral diplomacy

Powers of the General Assembly

Although the UNGA does not have the authority to enforce binding decisions like the Security Council, it plays a crucial role in shaping international norms and global consensus.

Its main powers include:

- Discussing and making recommendations on international peace and security
- Promoting the development of international law
- Encouraging respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity
- Approving the UN budget
- Electing non-permanent members of the Security Council
- Adopting resolutions that influence global political standards

The General Assembly is particularly important when issues involve sovereignty, non-intervention, and respect for international law, as it represents the collective voice of the international community.

II. Introduction to the Topic

The principle of sovereignty is a cornerstone of international law. Article 2(1) and 2(4) of the UN Charter affirm the sovereign equality of states and prohibit the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state.

Recent allegations regarding unauthorized incursions and actions by the United States into the territory of Venezuela have revived global debates about sovereignty, non-intervention, and external involvement in domestic political crises.

The issue challenges the balance between:

- Respect for sovereignty
- Promotion of democracy and human rights
- Enforcement of international law
- Regional stability in Latin America

III. Historical Background of U.S.–Venezuela Relations

Relations between the United States and Venezuela have been tense for over two decades.

Tensions escalated under Hugo Chávez (1999–2013), who adopted strong anti-U.S. policies and rhetoric.

Under Nicolás Maduro, political instability deepened due to contested elections, economic collapse, and social unrest.

In 2019, the United States formally recognized opposition leader Juan Guaidó as interim president, significantly increasing diplomatic tensions.

Since then, allegations have included:

- Intelligence operations
- Support for opposition actors
- Maritime and security operations near Venezuelan territory
- Economic sanctions

The United States has justified its actions as efforts to restore democracy and combat narcotrafficking, while Venezuela has characterized them as violations of sovereignty and territorial integrity.

IV. Legal Framework

The debate centers around fundamental principles of international law:

1. State Sovereignty

Every state has exclusive authority over its territory and political independence.

2. Non-Intervention

States must refrain from intervening in the internal affairs of other states.

3. Prohibition of the Use of Force

Under Article 2(4) of the UN Charter, states may not use force against the territorial integrity or political independence of another state.

4. Self-Defense (Article 51)

Force may only be used in response to an armed attack.

The International Court of Justice has repeatedly affirmed that respect for sovereignty is essential for maintaining international peace and stability.

V. Current Situation (2026 Context)

As of 2026:

- Venezuela continues to face economic hardship and political polarization.
- U.S. sanctions remain in place and are widely debated internationally.
- Allegations of covert operations and territorial violations continue to surface.
- Latin American states are divided in their diplomatic positions.

The issue has broader implications for:

- Regional security in Latin America
- U.S.–Latin America relations
- The global interpretation of sovereignty
- The credibility of international law

VI. Key Questions for Debate

Delegates should consider:

1. What legally constitutes an illegal incursion under international law?
2. Do sanctions amount to a violation of sovereignty?
3. Can democracy promotion justify external intervention?
4. What mechanisms can the UNGA use to address alleged violations?
5. How can escalation be prevented while ensuring accountability?

VII. Conclusion

The alleged illegal incursions into Venezuelan territory raise fundamental questions about the application of sovereignty in modern geopolitics.

For the United Nations General Assembly, this issue represents an opportunity to:

- Reaffirm the principle of sovereign equality
- Promote peaceful dispute resolution
- Strengthen multilateral dialogue
- Clarify the limits of external intervention

Delegates must carefully balance legal principles, geopolitical realities, and humanitarian concerns in order to propose a resolution that reinforces international stability and respect for the UN Charter.

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